Menus

Resources +3

Use cases

People should be able to do the following using assistive technology:

- Navigate to, open, and close a menu
- Navigate between and select menu items

Interaction & style

Menu items need certain cues to clearly show when they're selected:

- By default, menu items change shape and color when selected
- The default color contrast is 3:1 between selected and unselected menu items
- It's recommended to include another visual cue, like a checkmark

Use multiple visual cues like color, shape, and icons to show that an item is selected

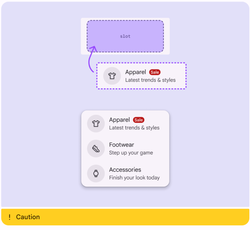
Flexibility & slots

Use caution when adding slots to menus:

- Make sure the menu remains accessible
- Elements must follow the rules and interaction patterns of the menu component
- Keep the same menu item padding
- Targets should be 48x48dp or larger

Don't add buttons, switches, or other direct actions into the menu item. Nested elements should only perform one action. Adding multiple actions can break keyboard navigation and screen reader functionality.

More on slots in menus



Reserve the use of slots for use cases that maintain the menu's accessibility and functionality

Focus

Initial focus

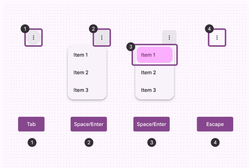
When a menu opens, focus should be placed on the first menu item. This allows people using a keyboard or other assistive technologies to begin navigating the menu immediately.

Exiting a menu

People expect to exit a menu by:

- Selecting an option
- Tapping **Escape** or outside of the menu
- Using the system back button

Where focus is placed after closing the menu depends on the app.



Keyboard navigation on Android and web:

1. **Tab** to select a menu item
2. **Space** or **Enter** to open a menu
3. **Space** or **Enter** to select a menu item
4. **Escape** to close a menu

Keyboard navigation

Keys	Actions
Tab	Focus lands on menu
Space or **Enter**	For closed menus: Opens menu or submenu For open menus: Selects a menu item
Up and **Down** arrows	For closed menus: Opens menu For open menus: Moves focus to the next item
Left and **Right** arrows	Opens or closes a submenu
Letters	Focus moves to the next menu item starting with letter
Escape	Closes menu

Interactability

Disabled menu items can receive focus but aren't selectable.

Dividers and gaps can't receive focus.

Disabled menu items can receive focus

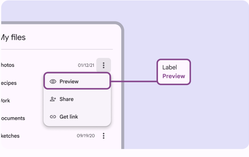
A divider or gap can't receive focus

Labeling elements

Accessibility labels are used with assistive technology devices like screen readers.

The accessibility label should be the same as the menu item text.

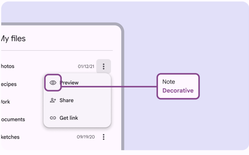
The role is dependent on platform.



The menu item's accessibility label aligns with the UI text

Element	A11y label	Role (Web)	Role (Android Views)	Role (Jetpack Compose)
Menu item text	Preview	Menu item	Generic actionable element	Generic actionable element

For menu items with text and an icon, the icon's accessibility label should be marked as **decorative** to avoid redundant verbalizations.



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